

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Piece Improvement and Exchanges

Worst-piece repair, outposts, files, color complexes, and trade decisions

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Find Your Worst Piece



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Improving the least useful piece can improve every other piece at once.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

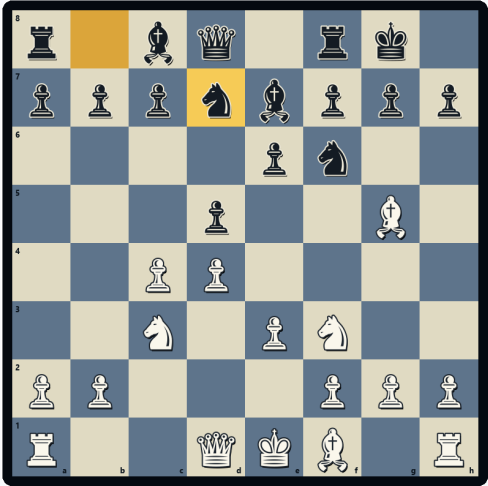
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Loose Pieces Tell The Truth



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Identify what is loose, then ask which forcing move can exploit it.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

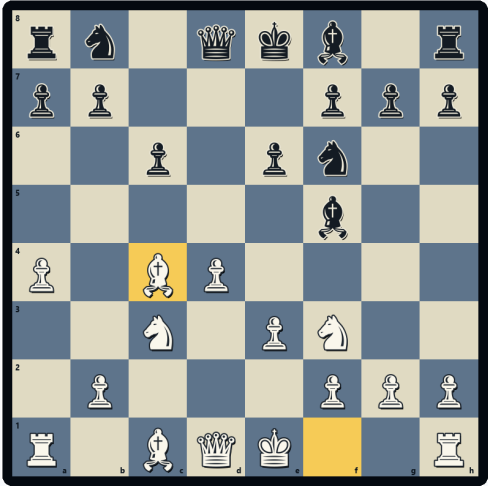
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Find The Important File



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Judge a file by its destination, control, and ability to support invasion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

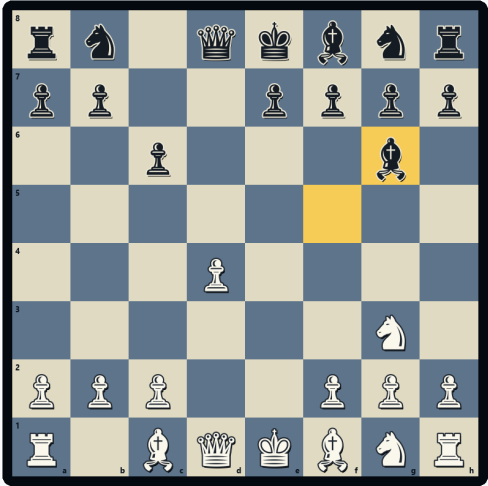
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4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Spot The Real Weakness



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Call it real only if you can attack it, increase pressure, or force passivity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

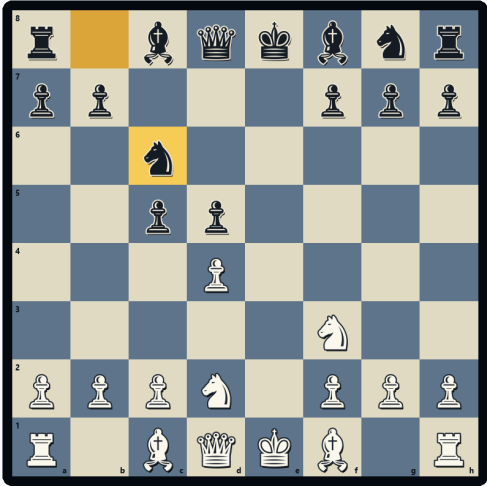
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Improve Before You Attack



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Bring the least active useful piece into play before forcing the position open.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. When To Trade Pieces



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Evaluate the position after the exchange, not the pieces disappearing from it.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

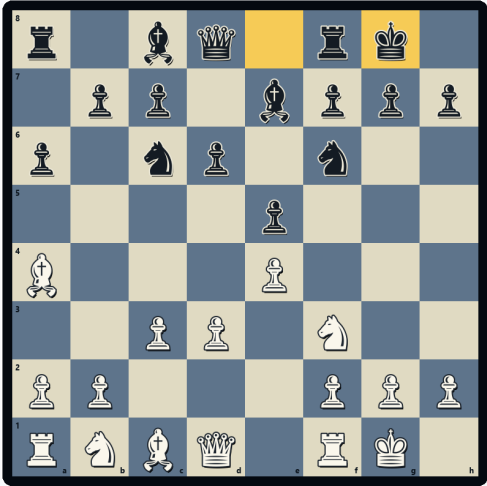
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. When Not To Trade Pieces



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Decline exchanges when your piece, space, or tension forces the opponent to remain uncomfortable.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

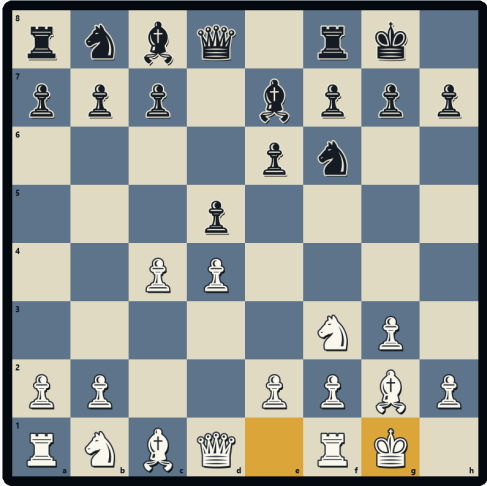
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Create A Second Weakness



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Fix one weakness, then create another where the same defenders cannot serve both.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Good Bishop Or Bad Bishop?



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Judge its diagonals, targets, and defensive duties in the actual position.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

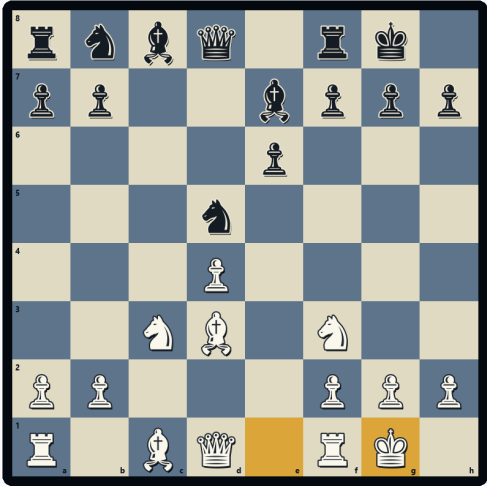
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Build A Real Outpost



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Use a square that cannot be chased and from which the piece influences something important.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Use A Space Advantage



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Use extra territory to improve pieces and restrict breaks before forcing action.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

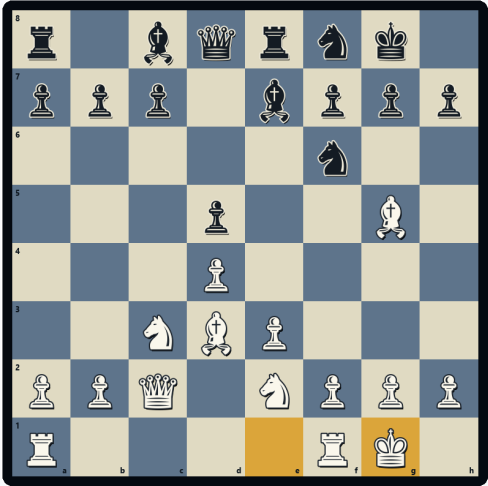
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Control A Color Complex



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Enter through one square, then transfer to another faster than the defense can respond.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

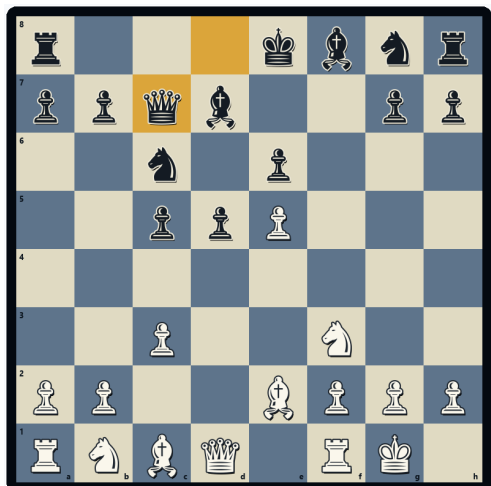
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Exchange The Best Defender



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Identify the piece whose removal changes the opponent's entire defensive geometry.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Oe7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

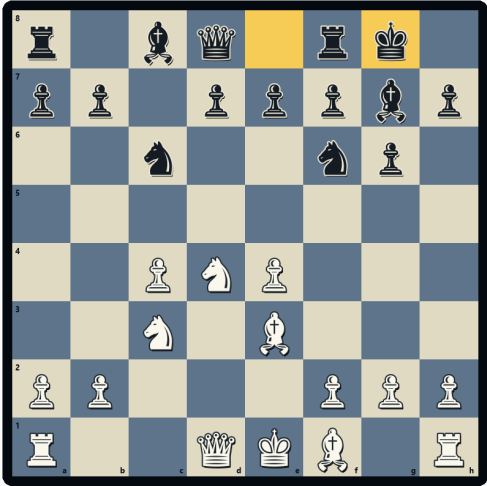
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Make Your Pieces Work Together



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Choose a target or break, then give each piece a compatible job.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

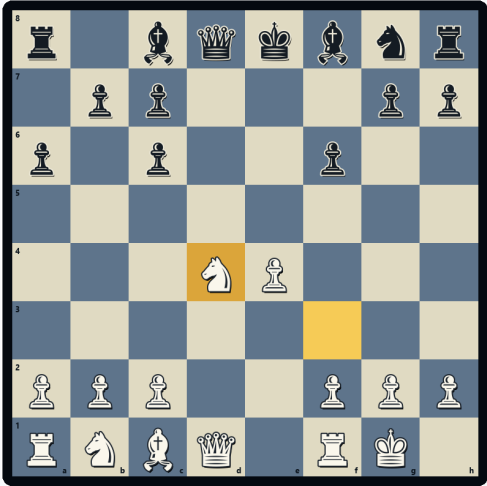
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Knight Or Bishop?



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Choose the piece whose strengths match the likely pawn breaks and targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

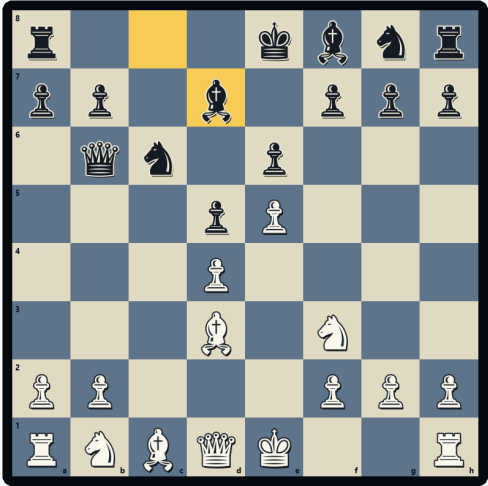
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Compare Final Positions



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Compare material, king safety, activity, structure, and practical difficulty at the endpoint.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

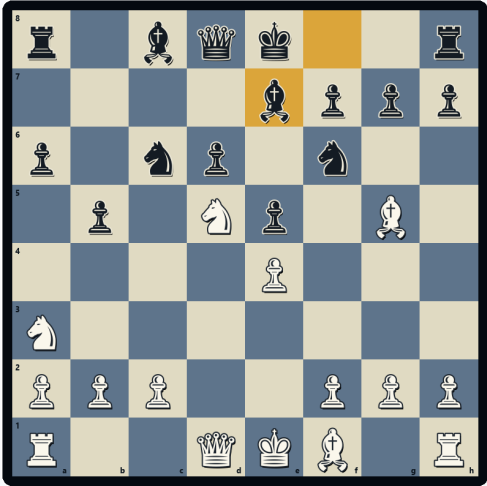
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Opposition Is About Access



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Use direct or distant opposition only when it wins access to a needed square.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

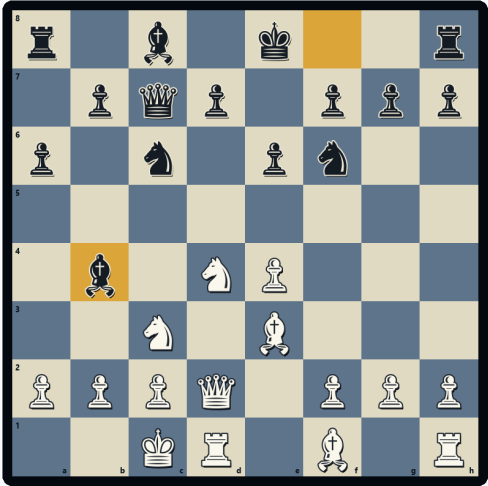
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Choose Activity In Rook Endgames



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Seek checks, attacks from the side or rear, and access behind passed pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

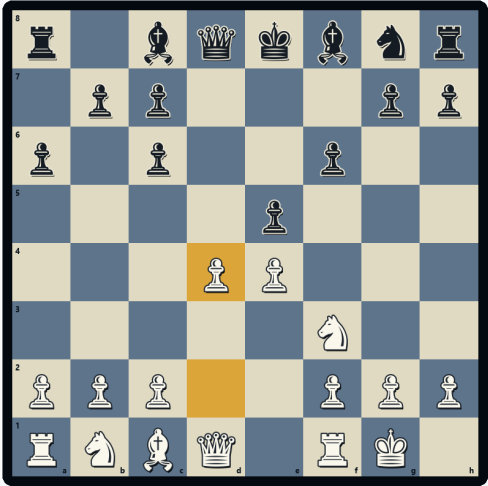
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Convert An Extra Pawn



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Activate the king and pieces, restrict counterplay, then use the majority to create a passed pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

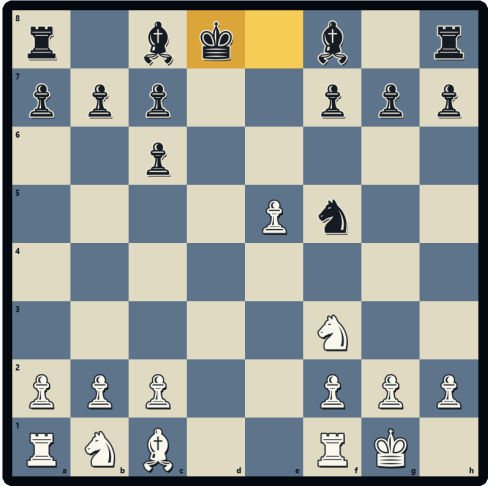
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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. When You Have No Idea What To Do



PIECE IMPROVEMENT AND EXCHANGES

POSITION PROMPT

Remove immediate danger, improve the worst piece, or preserve useful options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.